

THE CROSSROADS

ANAND UTSAV 2026

EVER
ROOTED
IN THE
TRUTH.

The Crossroads believes that truth is everyone's own nature and every form of creativity is an expression of truth. This vision enabled us to envision The Crossroads as a space where fresh voices rise, ideas collide, and the next generation of writers find their stage. At The Crossroads, we believe that every story matters.

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#8 YEARS@CIRS

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The Dancing Parasite is a haunting poem about the mental parasites that take over the mind, wrenching it from our grasp and leaving us as helpless spectators. This poem was a submission for the prestigious Foyle Young Poets Award as well.

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The Western Canonization of Satyajit Ray

Any Western conversation about cinema inevitably brings in Satyajit Ray and stops there. Other indigenous filmmakers have never been accorded the fame that Satyajit Ray enjoys, but for what reason? Their art is definitely no less. This article delves into the Western system's views of Indian cinema and all that it routinely ignores. The Western viewpoint has flattened these filmmakers into stereotypes, according to its own cinematic frameworks.

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THE EDITORIAL

The end of September in CIRS officially heralds the three months that treat academics as an optional activity. October brings Anand Utsav and the insane amount of preparation that goes into it, while November disappears in the flurry of Masquerades. Naturally, you would assume these are the three favorite months of every CIRS student, and I am no exception. Three years ago, however, it was a very different picture. The onset of October was my worst nightmare.

Eighth-grade me spent every hour of every day either studying or cracking jokes about everything under the sun, and I was expecting the usual routine: eat, sleep, have fun till 8th, study in the 9th and 10th, leave, study in some college, and find a job. I didn't act, I didn't sing, I didn't dance, I didn't have any innate skill to be proud of. All that led to my believing that I was destined to be a gray character in the crowd. In hindsight, who I used to be was a gray character not because of a lack of talent, but a lack of vision. I believed I would never be great, but neither did I want to be. I did not have dreams, aspirations, goals; I was simply drifting.

I walked into ninth grade not knowing I would walk out forever changed. The first challenge I faced came disguised as privilege: I joined Vanguard assuming we'd do a few activities in the name of learning and emerge the same. What I didn't anticipate was all that would be expected of me. I was expected to actually put effort into improvement, to want to become better, and to be willing to work for it. It was only once this passivity had been eradicated that I began to look around me for things to learn, things to be passionate about.

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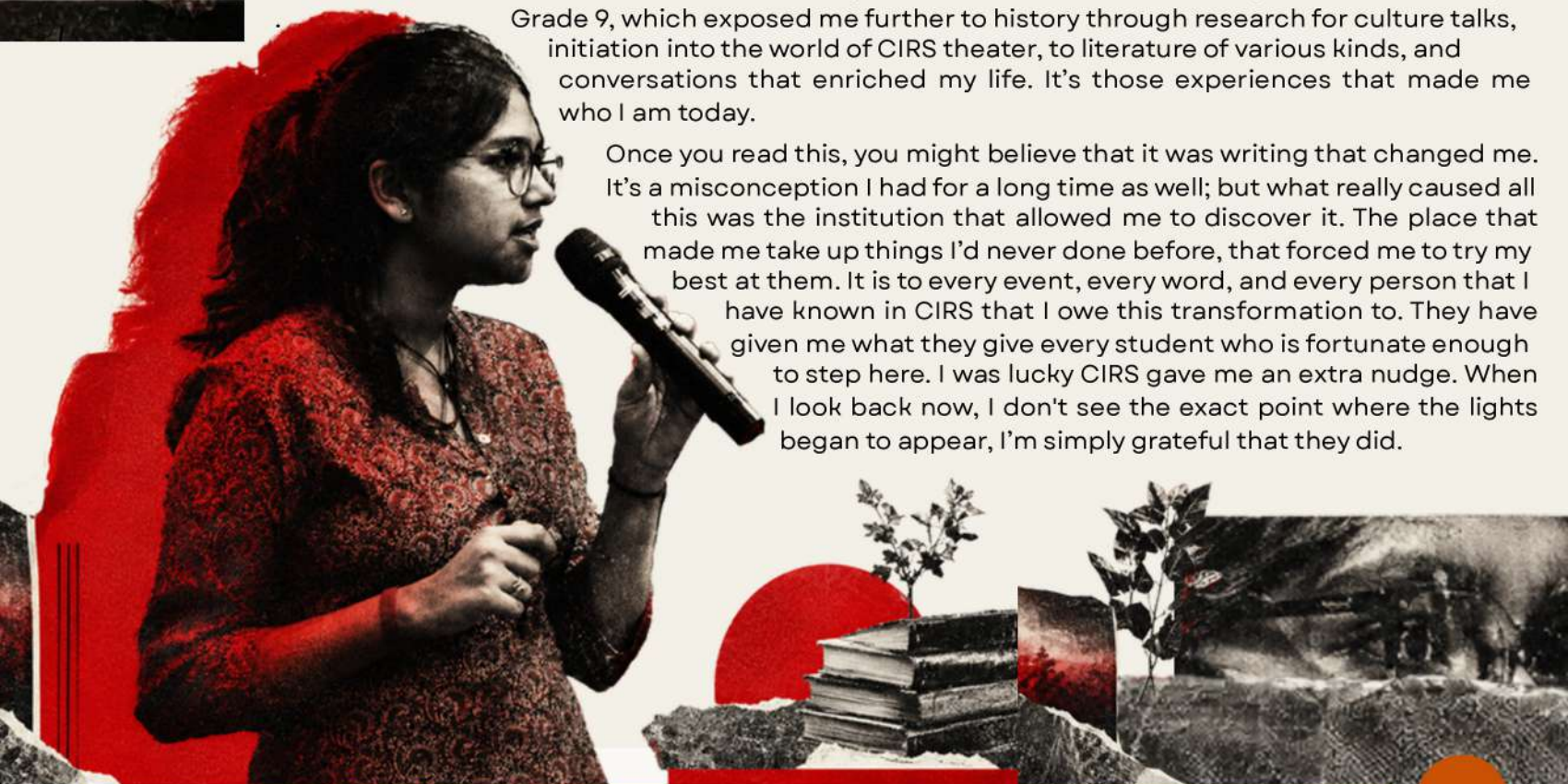
**WHEN I LOOK BACK NOW, I DON'T
SEE THE EXACT POINT WHERE
THE LIGHTS BEGAN TO APPEAR;
I'M SIMPLY GRATEFUL THAT
THEY DID.**

”



My savior came in the form of The Crossroads, one of the major reasons I am able in any way to write this today. Finding my forte in writing propelled my confidence by leagues. I had finally found something that I loved, something I could excel at. It gave me the voice I had never had: though I was outspoken, I was never confident in what I was saying. My passion and flair for writing were a large part of the identity I was discovering: my writing gave me an avenue to focus my goals, improve my literary skills, and expand my knowledge of the world. And it led to opening doors that had earlier remained elusive. Another doorway to who I am now was becoming Cultural Secretary in Grade 9, which exposed me further to history through research for culture talks, initiation into the world of CIRS theater, to literature of various kinds, and conversations that enriched my life. It's those experiences that made me who I am today.

Once you read this, you might believe that it was writing that changed me. It's a misconception I had for a long time as well; but what really caused all this was the institution that allowed me to discover it. The place that made me take up things I'd never done before, that forced me to try my best at them. It is to every event, every word, and every person that I have known in CIRS that I owe this transformation to. They have given me what they give every student who is fortunate enough to step here. I was lucky CIRS gave me an extra nudge. When I look back now, I don't see the exact point where the lights began to appear, I'm simply grateful that they did.



Crossroads Editorial Team '26

MESSAGE TO THE NEXT TEAM

Crossroads. A random collection of (insanely talented) people who grew as a family, created amazing issues and even better memories. As we leave with so many irreplaceable experiences, bonds, and knowledge, we want you to know that The Crossroads has always been so much more than just the magazine itself: it's a place to grow, to make mistakes, and above all - to learn from each other. This opportunity has given us more than we could've ever asked for, and the only thing we ask from all of you is that you know the privilege and responsibility that comes with being a part of one of the most influential and long-standing clubs in school. Every page you design, every word you proofread, and every Creative Corner you curate is a reflection of the literary talent and creative expression of every single individual in this school. So carry that responsibility with earnestness, pride, and of course a whole lot of fun (like we did)! We wish you all the very best, and hope that you take this amazing magazine to better and better heights.

THE DANCING PARASITE

Viraj Vijaykumar Lal
IB I YR

before the jasmine died.

foraging old ghosts,
i do not recall where my mind
ends and it begins.

i remember when stillness was a
choice –
before the jasmine died on the
trellis, before the kitchen smelled
of nothing.

it unclenched the crease behind
my ear and drank.

then it burrowed:
a colony in the cracks and
crevices,
an infestation in the folds of my
hippocampus.

now i am two things: a stone at
the bottom of a river,
and the river itself.

now watch what i become: drunk
without a pint.
a shaitan who paces, who
mutters, who claws at wallpaper.
a bonfire eating its own legs.

the dance takes me to the house,
no longer home,
stripping the jasmine from the
trellis –
years of my mother's hands,
scattered.
the parasite taught me this
dance:

thrash and call it freedom,
burn and call it passion,
collapse and call it rest.

and when my truth screams, it
stops,
not by shhh,
but by eating the sound before it
reaches the air.



BEYOND The HEADLINES

India is one of the fastest-growing economies in the world. In fact, India recorded a strong 7.8% real economic growth in the first quarter of the fiscal year 2027. To put this into perspective, the British GDP grew 1.2% while the Chinese economy grew 4.3% in the same period.

However, despite this, Prime Minister Narendra Modi posted a reel, appealing to Indians to not go on “foreign tours”, host “abroad destination weddings” and stop buying gold. We are getting richer, aren’t we? Why not spend more as well on luxury foreign products? Surely, a getaway in the Swiss Alps sounds more appealing than a road trip to the neighboring state.

But what does this growth mean for the average Indian? Over the past few years, our economic growth was accompanied by a significant decrease in absolute poverty, which shrank to 5.3% of the population in 2023 from 27.1% in 2011. Subsequently, employment levels also increased from 47.5 crore people in 2017-18 to 64.33 crore people in 2023-24.

Yet, on the flip side, in 1990, the top 1% of adults had a 10.5% share of national income. But now, the top 1% of adults own 22.6% of the entire country’s wealth.

This clearly illustrates how a growing economy does not necessarily increase incomes in the entire economy and benefit everyone proportionally.

But coming back to Mr Modi, let’s say your household income has truly increased. Why is the government stopping you from buying your “Made in Germany” BMWs or “Made in Switzerland” chocolates?

You see, even when a household earns more, spending that income at home or abroad can have entirely different effects on the Indian economy and its actual future growth. Let us consider a wedding hosted in India. All the wedding-related expenses will be provided to Indians, be it local hotels, caterers, photographers, or drivers. This keeps our money within the economy and supports local livelihoods.

However, demand for gold and other foreign goods and services introduces a new challenge. India has to import gold from the rest of the world. And the issue is that we have to pay in their currency. In order to do that, we have to sell the rupee and buy the foreign currency in a place called the Foreign Exchange Market (Forex Market) - a place for currency trading.

Hence, by selling the rupee in the Forex Market, the supply of the rupee increases. According to basic economics, this means that the rupee depreciates against other currencies in a floating exchange rate. This makes foreign goods more expensive for all Indians.

For example, in the April-August period, India's crude oil import bill jumped 48.4% in US dollar terms, rising from \$50.4 billion to \$74.8 billion. While it was driven primarily by the Middle East conflict, the depreciating currency caused the bill to skyrocket by 62% in rupees even though the quantity ordered fell by 0.4%.

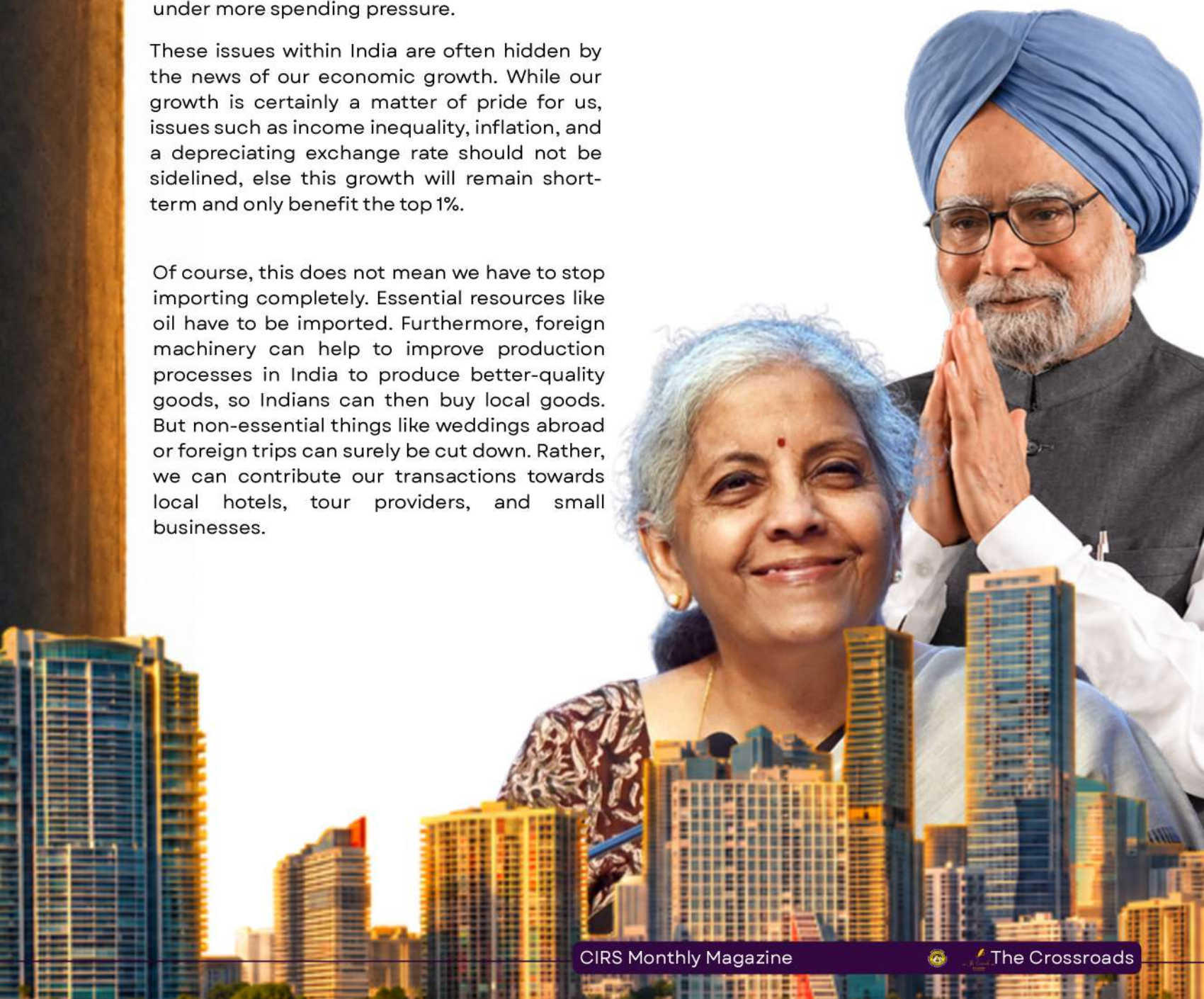
While imports cannot fully contribute to inflation, such examples show how our own demand for imports increases inflation. This inflation ripples throughout the entire domestic economy. In August 2026, India's retail inflation was 4.82%, while food inflation reached 5.95%, putting lower-income earners under more spending pressure.

These issues within India are often hidden by the news of our economic growth. While our growth is certainly a matter of pride for us, issues such as income inequality, inflation, and a depreciating exchange rate should not be sidelined, else this growth will remain short-term and only benefit the top 1%.

Of course, this does not mean we have to stop importing completely. Essential resources like oil have to be imported. Furthermore, foreign machinery can help to improve production processes in India to produce better-quality goods, so Indians can then buy local goods. But non-essential things like weddings abroad or foreign trips can surely be cut down. Rather, we can contribute our transactions towards local hotels, tour providers, and small businesses.

This will help lower-income earners in the economy earn more, making the benefits of economic growth more evenly distributed. Furthermore, it prevents our exchange rate from depreciating thanks to reduced imports. At the same time, it is important to invest in skills and create secure, better-paying jobs, so that young Indians can also benefit from economic growth.

So, are we actually growing with India's economic growth? Statistics have shown that we have certainly benefited as more people are employed, poverty has decreased, and our national incomes have increased. However, the GDP growth rate is not enough to show that we have grown. It does not tell us whether the youth are getting jobs, whether income disparity is widening, and how much each person is benefiting from these gains. And in order to feel that personal growth, it is time to live on the principles of an Aatmanirbar Bharat.



BHARAT'S BEYOND THE STRAITS ENERGY

Divyam Gupta | IB | YR

Not limited to mere supply chains or owning a strait, the 21st century demands that every country either be a part of the Western cult to secure energy (if you cannot produce it), which is failing miserably, or do something on its own. While conflicts monopolize the headlines, the war is geoeconomic – like a current – calm on the surface, but rough and turbulent underneath. Sanctions appear more frequently than LaLiga games, while freight insurance caps and supply chain weaponization of critical rare earth minerals are a bigger display of power today than fighter jets. A quarter of the planet's primary energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz, the Bab el-Mandeb, and the Strait of Malacca; these narrow and crowded maritime arteries are tumors to global energy security. And disruptions, whether by state-sponsored militants or governments 11,000 km away, send shock waves through the global energy markets. In this era, sadly, the true geopolitical and geoeconomic power lies in the ability to decouple national survival from these volatile, external maritime corridors. With 74% of chief economists of the World Economic Forum claiming that India has the strongest growth outlook, the detail is that 85% of Bharat's crude is imported from rentier nations. The country's appetite is increasing exponentially, yet the nation holds reserves for only about 78 days. This can lead to disasters worse than those seen in 1991. These issues can lead to severe political instability and a halt in economic growth. With the Forex reserves falling and rising, along with the cost of goods in the market, the nation will certainly not be in a great position. To navigate through this byzantine situation, Bharat astutely aligned itself multilaterally. Rather than depending solely on the Middle East, as has been the trend,



Bharat also effectively saves Forex by buying discounted Russian crude and constantly hunting for new trade corridors to keep consumer prices from instantly spiraling. Though well planned, walking the knife's edge is only a temporary fix in this battle of snakes. Ultimately, to protect its interests, India faces a stark choice: import enough oil even in times of no crisis, as China does (which has more oil than the 32 members of the International Energy Agency combined!), or diversify its energy sources by expanding into ethanol, methanol, nuclear energy, and green hydrogen. Ethanol and Methanol have emerged as the twin pillars of our government's interest in the transition toward alternative energy; simultaneously, green hydrogen is the next aim of the entire world.



The cornerstone of Bharat's transition into *aatmanirbharta* in energy is ethanol. It is undisputably the king of controversy in the automobile industry and a part of the supposed solution to make Bharat energy-secure. Ethanol is not just an environmental initiative; it is geoeconomic resilience. Billions of dollars that flow outward are retained by slashing crude imports and can alternatively be used for the import and usage of other merit goods. Since 2014, ethanol blending has saved the nation ₹1.9-₹1.98 lakh crore. Finishing the project of E20 has various positive effects on paper, but the hasty implementation meant that the automobiles were not ready for the new fuel, and NITI Aayog's warning about the same was visible through massive

public outrage. The ethanol industry pumps massive liquidity into the rural agrarian economy.

Converting excess or unfit agricultural outputs to this carbon-efficient fuel led to the reduction of the supply of important foodstuffs like maize to the market, as farmers opted to sell to the ethanol companies for better pay. Bharat, a usual exporter, had to net import 0.9 metric tonnes of maize to suffice the demand. Contrastingly, ethanol also protects the nation from disputes and conflicts at maritime chokepoints by reducing the demand.

While ethanol can be seen as the practical present, the future belongs to Green Hydrogen. The plan of decarbonizing steel refining and fertilizer production requires 5 MMT Green Hydrogen output annually by 2030. While converting solar and water into a fuel within the borders of the country represents the pinnacle of strategic independence, the cost of doing so is three times higher than the one involved in using gray hydrogen from fossil fuels. Producing electrolyzers is a move from being dependent on Middle Eastern oil to being dependent on minerals - particularly Chinese sourced.

Though ethanol and green hydrogen can be used for specific niche areas, like light passenger vehicles, Bharat is looking at methanol as a more dynamic substitute. Using NITI Aayog's Methanol Economy, the fuel is used as a strong complement to ethanol.

The supremacy of this fuel lies in its sourcing: unsustainable and unproductive goods like high-ash coal, municipal waste, and agricultural biomass. Methanol's applications can revolutionise heavy transport, inland marine transport, and coastal shipping by M15 blending. It also serves as a cleaner alternative to industrial generators. Having the capability to blend with LPG and burn without residue, it can be used for household cooking as well. By building this flex-fuel infrastructure with multiple alternative fuels, Bharat is passively diversifying to reduce crude requirements and eventually reach energy security.

At length, Bharat's energy future is not about getting the right policy, which is impossible in a democracy. But Bharat can surely make calculated trade-offs and implement structural changes at a realistic pace to make a sustainable and self-improving transition smooth. As the reality of this transition proves, ethanol walks a razor's edge with food security, while green hydrogen remains a costly geoeconomic gamble. Instead of wasting resources, Bharat has deployed a domestic matrix that contains ethanol for now, methanol for heavy transport, and hydrogen for tomorrow, forging an impenetrable internal shield.



लौग क्या कहेंगे?

RISHA MISHRA | IB | YR

In this generation, I consider myself and all the other girls living in CIRS very privileged to belong to families that gave us exposure to so many skills and put us on the path towards becoming the independent women we have always dreamed of being one day. However, if you look outside the campus, you would find so many other girls who would give anything to study in a more nurturing environment but are stopped - why? Not always because of financial constraints, and not always because the personal beliefs of their parents prohibit it. They are stopped because of what society will think of them, because of the opinions of others, because society can spread words that may bring "disrespect" to the girl's family. Why are so many of us taught to think about a so-called "reputation" that lies in the hands of a destructive society rather than in our own aspirations and goals, which are the actual roots of our reputation? Why do we have to guard an "honor" that isn't even really ours?

In many of the harassment or assault cases that we encounter on the news today, a similar pattern can be spotted where the family of the victim rarely approaches authorities to file complaints or take action against the accused because they think that their family's "reputation" will be spoiled.

Though society itself cannot be altered overnight, we can change our own mindsets first. The decisions we make about our lifestyles, careers, and aspirations shouldn't depend on how society will perceive them. Society will always have negative or positive opinions about everything we do, we have to learn how to control our decisions based on our circumstances and not based on the perception of others. So how do we begin to take that power back? It's simple: Why do we worship goddesses like Maa Durga or Maa Kali? Because they are fierce, unrestrained, and answer to no one. If society reveres them

for exactly those qualities, it must learn to accept its own daughters being independent and unapologetic in the same way. We must stop raising girls to be adjusting and quiet in the face of questions and instead let them explore every opportunity to achieve their own goals and express their ideas confidently.

This change starts at home. Parents and siblings should ask for a girl's opinion in even the smallest family decisions, so she learns early on that her voice carries weight. When a girl feels seen and respected within her own home, she builds the confidence to speak up in the world outside it, without constantly asking herself, "What will society think of me?" More importantly, she stops having to defend herself every time society questions her, because society's opinion shouldn't matter as long as she knows her path and her actions align with her own values.

Ultimately, we shouldn't be required to guard an "honor" that was never ours to begin with. On the contrary we must ensure that we are internally satisfied with our decisions and actions rather than pleasing a stifling society with them. The only "honor" we must guard is our own.



KALAVRINDAM



Every masterpiece begins the same way: a blank canvas staring right into the artist's soul. There the artist stands, with a brilliant idea in mind but no self-confidence. In fact, one of the planet's most renowned artists, Vincent Van Gogh, didn't even take up painting seriously until he was 27 years old, as he was constantly wrestling with the fear of failure, a fear that followed him into the later parts of his life as well. Unfortunately, most of us face the same issue.

This is what led to the formation of Kalavrindam - a dedicated student art community; one that aims to nurture the minds and skills of young artists by providing them with an environment where they are free to express themselves without fear and self-doubt plaguing their minds. One that strives to shield blooming artistic minds from all the tragedies that befell masters like Van Gogh and to encourage the entire student body to pick up the craft.

The magnum opus of Kalavrindam undoubtedly took the form of our contributions to the Amrit Yatra celebrations - a series of five paintings depicting the Gita Panchamrit, showing that art has a deep and profound connection to spiritual traditions. These paintings now adorn the walls of the ground floor's Lecture Theatre.

Our most recent project, for which we have worked tirelessly, is our Anand Utsav feature - grand paintings of the Ramayan, re-imaginings of Picasso's works, and CIRS depicted with the backdrop of Van Gogh's unforgettable Starry Night.

This art community looks forward to many more minds imagining the most creative ideas, working with overcrowded color palettes and messy workstations. Art teaches one more than just filling in colors; instead, it colors the minds of artists with vivid shades of exploration. For example, when one figures out how to get that exact shade of paint by the ultimate method: trial and error, they expand their minds and reach into the realms of imagination and curiosity, which, on a larger scale, allows them to be flexible and observe the world around them through different perspectives, contributing to their personality at large. The yearly Wall Magazines in our school brings all students from every house together to create art. These Wall Magazines encourage people to give art a whirl and explore this vibrant field. In these moments, standard skill levels don't matter; everyone joins in to help, whether they know how to master a brush or have never held one before!

Through dedication, hard work, and a few mishaps along the way, we hope to show that young minds can reach extraordinary heights when guided with love and allowed self-expression in the right environment. As this special community continues to grow, it makes its mark on the canvas of the school's history - filling in and transforming blank spaces into vibrant and creative expressions of faith, devotion, timeless truths, and the vast possibilities we have only now begun to imagine.

On November 19, 2023, a helicopter manned by 10 men set down on the deck of the car carrier *Galaxy Leader* as it crossed the Red Sea. Less than an hour later, the ship's crew of 25 men was under the custody of the Houthis. The Houthis, as they stand, dominate northern Yemen, despite the fact that only a few governments acknowledge them as the legitimate rulers of Yemen. They have no ideal navy to control the sea, yet they sail the ship to the harbor and convert it into a tourist destination.

Three years on, the throttle that followed matters a lot more than the hijacking itself. Suez Canal container volumes fell by as much as 90 percent in 2024 and were forced to go through the Cape of Good Hope, according to Coface - a French trade-credit insurer - as shipping companies rerouted around Africa rather than risk the Red Sea. Some of that traffic has still not returned.

Strength of military power is often gauged by the size of the military forces and the extent of monetary backing available, but Yemen ranks close to last on both those tables. It has, rather, something more precarious to negotiate with - the annoyingly long coastline in one of the busiest shipping lanes, and the determination to keep shooting anything passing through it.

The strategic location of Ukraine in the Black Sea differs significantly in this regard. Its fleet was not very numerous and had lost several vessels while defending Snake Island and Odessa during the first days of the war. Ukraine, however, wagered on Neptune anti-ship missiles that targeted the Russian cruiser *Moskva* in April 2022, complementing the fleet of cheap drones that could be easily sacrificed in case one attack failed. The result? By the end of 2023, Ukraine drove the main forces of Russia's Black Sea Fleet out of Sevastopol and into Novorossiysk, which was far less advantageous with regard to the Crimean operations.

In October 2022 and July 2023, Ukraine's security services attacked the Kerch Bridge - the only major land route linking Crimea with multiple missile attacks - thus forcing Russia to rely on one overland route known as R-280, which the Russian government itself describes as the Novorossiysk highway. This route became a prime target for attacks from 2022 to 2026: drones would create a blind spot for Russian radar systems and then attack the convoys carrying fuel and the bridges that were being built as replacements. According to ACLED, a monitor of armed conflicts, there were over 200 drone attacks on shipping in the Sea of Azov in July alone. So here, once again, we see Ukraine, a smaller state in comparison to Russia, holding the cards.

Why do small countries keep winning?

Shaurya Bhartia- XII



The situation in Greenland is of an entirely different kind. Neither blockades of sea routes nor drone firings exist in its vicinity. Denmark has its grounds in international law and diplomatic retaliation, making the annexation process costlier rather than making it impossible to carry out. The population of Greenland is around 57,000. It has been living under the threat of being taken away forcefully by the Americans for almost two years now due to its rare earth resources and Arctic location. But the resistance to this has been made clear by the Prime Minister of Denmark, Mette Frederiksen, in January: "You cannot annex another country, not even with an argument about international security."

First, there is the cost. An unmanned naval vehicle able to disable a warship can apparently be constructed for no more than the price of a car, and that is why a state that has practically no navy can pose a threat to a far bigger one. Secondly, alliance and domestic politics of the latter state play an even greater role than its real military capabilities.

Taiwan complicates this pattern and is an outlier and deliberately so. It is not a small, weak state in the way Yemen or Niger are; its semiconductor industry makes it one of the most economically consequential places on Earth, especially now after the AI boom; its hand is closer in kind to wealth. Its defense plan, called 'Hellscape' by the American admiral who coined the term and taken up by Taiwanese officials since it borrows the same logic anyway: flooding the strait facing China with cheap drones rather than trying to outbuild its navy ship for ship, but this is only a contingency plan never tested.

But there are exemptions.

Nigeria's uranium row with France is an exemption, although its conclusion was not as straightforward as one would expect from a bad hand. Following a 2023 coup in Niger, the government expropriated the mines operated by the French firm Orano for many years and expelled the French troops, believing that supplying about 20% of uranium to France gives it a strong card. However, several aspects complicated this plan. First, the neighboring countries, members of ECOWAS, closed their borders and banking system. Second, the arbitration lawsuit filed by Orano caused concern among the potential buyers of the contested uranium. Finally, at that time, France had already managed to diversify itself to Kazakhstan and Canada, however it is difficult to single out which of them played the leading role. The only thing known is that according to the Financial Times: in early 2026, about 1,000 metric tons of uranium taken from Orano stayed at a military air base near Niamey without any sales, and ever since negotiations with the Russians, Chinese, and Americans have been taking place there.

Consider the *Galaxy Leader*: Struck by an Israeli aircraft in July 2025, it now lies motionless in shallow water off the Yemeni coast, neither fully sunk nor salvaged. It is a perfect metaphor for the modern world: a place where major global disputes no longer resolve, but simply rust away in a permanent stalemate.



FROM DOUBT TO DISCOVERY

Shivansh Biyani IB I YR

Chyk

As a 12-year-old, I used to believe that God did not exist and that the supernatural power we call 'God' was a concept created by tribal leaders in ancient times to establish their own societal rules and regulations. For example the use of natural calamities by such leaders as an expression of God's anger to create and enforce practices that constitute their ideal way of living in a society. I also believed that science and religion could not coexist, and that science was a greater force because of its ability to answer every question with proof, whereas religion seemed unable to keep up with my curiosity. I ended up assuming most of the 'knowledge' I had about religion without even caring to truly explore it.

Then, I came to CIRS, where my day started with Spiritual Classes, and Aartis were compulsory. It all felt pointless, and initially I cold-shouldered them. While being forced to sit through them, I could not avoid the discussions that revealed the rationale behind our daily spiritual practices, which I believed were superstition. I was being exposed to religion, and slowly I began to understand: What does it mean? What is its purpose? Slowly, my assumed understanding of GOD shattered into pieces. I understood that our religion never asked us to have blind faith; rather, it was always about rationally seeking the truth.

Then in 10th grade, CHYK came into the picture. Right then, I was just at the shore, and the entire ocean awaited me. I got introduced to Seva, Study, and Sadhana. CHYK is not only responsible for my intellectual transformation, but also for my holistic transformation on the basis of body, mind, and intellect. Like many people my age, I initially assumed that anything related to spirituality meant preachy and boring lectures. CHYK proved to be the exact opposite: an open, judgment-free space where no question was too taboo to ask and personal opinions were appreciated.



Through the weekly classes, we discussed various topics such as freedom and licentiousness, and freely shared our opinions. Then we studied Kindle Life and dived into what our 7,000-year time-tested, ever-applicable knowledge had to tell us. This was true spiritual understanding, not blind faith. We learned that our mind is simply a flow of thoughts, and when we direct these thoughts towards higher ideals, smaller distractions and petty anxieties automatically vanish. I also understood that science and religion have always co-existed. While objective science investigates the world outside, Vedanta is the subjective science that deals with the inner self. Our greatest scholars were not contradictory; they were brilliant intellects who were also staunch followers of our religion.

I was getting closer to God, but to reach him I have to understand Brahman, the force of life present in all of us. To do so, I must lose individuality, the ego that makes me distinguish myself from all others, even when the 'life-powering' factor in us is identical. I have still not lost that individual ego, but every step towards Brahman positively transforms my attitude towards people, society, and nation. This goal of reaching Brahman is the foundation of Seva, as it teaches us to look past our superficial differences, see everybody as one, and strive for the welfare of the collective.



ARE YOU AWAITING CHYK FOR YOUR TRANSFORMATION? BECAUSE CHYK AWAITS YOU!

Performing Seva also taught me to act without getting anxious about outcomes, which channelised my mental energy from worrying about results to utilising it for giving my absolute best towards a greater purpose in every task.

Then comes Sadhana, the practice which can directly connect us with the supreme power. It is meditating upon God through practices such as Japa, consciously and repeatedly taking the name of God with utmost focus. Practicing Japa helped me calm my mind and increased my focus exponentially. Its direct effect was seen in Academics when I scored 95% in my 10th Boards, even when I had never scored above 90% in 9th grade. It proved to me that spiritual practices do not pull you away from worldly duties and goals; rather, they enhance our capabilities to excel in them.

This is my journey of upliftment at the body, mind, and intellectual levels with CHYK. It turned my skepticism into inquiry and directed my mental energy to tasks that were more important. Are you awaiting CHYK for your transformation? Because CHYK awaits you!



There is a peculiar ritual that occurs whenever Indian cinema enters a Western conversation about "world cinema": someone says Satyajit Ray's name, and the conversation more or less ends there. He becomes the shorthand, acceptable, legible face of an entire nation's cinema spanning dozens of languages, regions, themes, and ideological positions. Kurosawa gets to represent Japan while still leaving room for Ozu, Mizoguchi, and Naruse; Sweden has Bergman, yet Sjöström and Widerberg are still part of the picture. But Ray is regularly asked to represent India alone, as if Ritwik Ghatak, Mrinal Sen, and a dozen others aren't relevant. This so-called "minor curatorial oversight" overshadows the astute pattern in canon formations that disguise themselves as accidents, but in actuality reveal what the canonizing culture is really looking for.

Ray's international ascent began with the Apu Trilogy's reception at Cannes and MoMA in the mid-1950s, and it's worth asking what made his work so immediately exportable when the work of his counterparts was not. What I've come to realize is that the answer lies in a greater depth than mere quality. Ghatak's *Meghe Dhaka Tara* and Sen's *Bhuvan Shome* are by most serious critical measures every bit as accomplished, so it couldn't be that... the true depth lies more in legibility. What I mean by this is Ray's Humanism, his Renoir-inflected visual grammar, his interest in individual psychological interiority, all charted comfortably and conveniently onto categories Western critics already possessed. He could be discussed using the same vocabulary applied to Italian neorealism or the more humanist strands of European art cinema. His films offered Western audiences a version of poverty and rural life that was legible as universal, sorrowful, dignified, and perhaps apolitical enough to be received as "human" rather than as statements.

Ghatak's work, by contrast, is openly disruptive in ways that resist most easy translation. His employment of sound, theatrical excess, and his denial of adopting psychological realism in favor of something closer to melodrama-as-political-rupture, were choices rooted specifically in the trauma of Partition and the Bengali refugee experience. They require a viewer fluent in that specific history and willing to acknowledge a film that doesn't smooth its anger into something palatable. Ghatak's brusque disinterest in legibility to audiences in Paris or New York is what cost him the canonization Ray received, showing that his films were no lesser than Ray's; they just weren't designed for export.

In hindsight, the argument worth making suggests the view that the Western art-cinema apparatus of the 1950s through 1970s (festival juries, distributors, the critical establishment writing for outlets) was not neutrally scanning the world for the "best" films. It was rather selecting a particular kind of Humanism, to be more specific, the one compatible with a post-war European sensibility that wanted to affirm universal human dignity while carefully avoiding films that indicated colonialism, caste, or the economic structures Western capital still benefited from. Ray's humanism is no doubt real and considerable, but it is also, not coincidentally, the version of Indian suffering least likely to implicate the viewer.

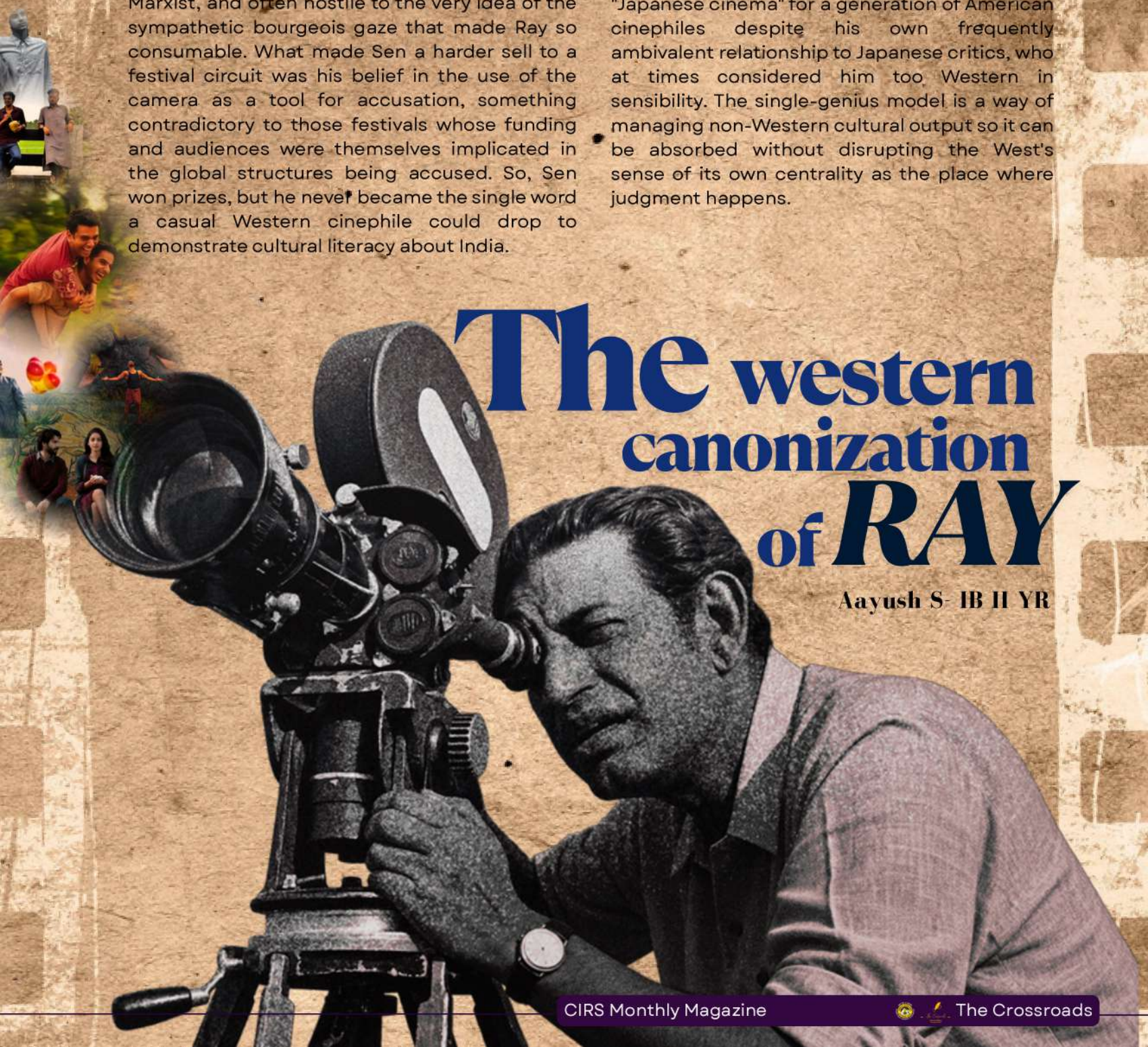
Mrinal Sen, though, fully understood this very dynamic and pushed directly against it. His later work, particularly through the 1970s, is explicitly Marxist, and often hostile to the very idea of the sympathetic bourgeois gaze that made Ray so consumable. What made Sen a harder sell to a festival circuit was his belief in the use of the camera as a tool for accusation, something contradictory to those festivals whose funding and audiences were themselves implicated in the global structures being accused. So, Sen won prizes, but he never became the single word a casual Western cinephile could drop to demonstrate cultural literacy about India.

The deeper we delve, we notice that there's a broader mechanism at work here that isn't specific to India. The Western art-cinema canon has historically preferred to admit non-Western cinemas one auteur at a time, as singular geniuses who transcend their national context, rather than as members of a wholly plural film culture. This subtle gameplay is what allows the West to consume difference without doing the harder work of understanding a cinema's internal debates, as in the arguments Ray, Ghatak, and Sen were actually having with one another about the form, politics and noticeably, the ethics of representing poverty. Reducing that ecosystem to a single representative name flattens a rich critical argument into a single answer, and conveniently, the West got to pick which answer.

This is the same logic that made Kurosawa "Japanese cinema" for a generation of American cinephiles despite his own frequently ambivalent relationship to Japanese critics, who at times considered him too Western in sensibility. The single-genius model is a way of managing non-Western cultural output so it can be absorbed without disrupting the West's sense of its own centrality as the place where judgment happens.

The western canonization of RAY

Aayush S - IB II YR



The cost of this isn't only historical fairness to Ghatak and Sen, though that matters. The cost is that Ray himself gets flattened in the process and turned into a "humanist master" rather than understood as one position within a remarkably contested field. Ray's own films contain real tension and ambivalence about class and rural life that gets smoothed over when he's treated as a monument rather than a participant in an argument. Against Ghatak's far angrier and more radical treatments of material similar to Ray's *Pather Panchali*, this acts as a sharpening of Ray's work, including his limits, in hindsight. Ray was, by his own later admission, less interested in direct political confrontation than in individual moral and emotional experience. And this, in my view, works as a compelling artistic choice that unfortunately becomes washed over when he is presented as simply "the best" rather than one pole amongst many in the debate on how Indian Cinema should represent Indian life.

Canons act as records of what a given critical culture at a given historical moment was capable of recognizing and metabolizing, rather than mere records of the "best works". The fact that Ghatak has only in recent decades begun receiving serious retrospective attention outside Bengali and Indian film circles, that too decades after his death, and largely through the efforts of scholars and restorationists rather than the original festival apparatus, tells us less about his talent than about how long it took the West to develop an adaptable cell or "checklist" for cinema.

Ray was undoubtedly exceptional in his field, yet one still has to pose a thought about what this says about the functioning of international cultural recognition. That an entire national cinema, spanning multiple languages and radically different political and aesthetic representations, could be represented for half a century by the one filmmaker whose work least threatened the frameworks already in place to receive it.

THEATER



Proscenium

FRAME IN A THEATER THAT SEPARATES THE MAIN STAGE FROM THE AUDIENCE

Down stage

THE PART OF THE STAGE THAT IS CLOSEST TO THE AUDIENCE

Mise-en-scene

"PLACING ON STAGE". IT REFERS TO EVERYTHING THAT APPEARS BEFORE THE CAMERA IN A FILM OR THEATER PRODUCTION

Blocking

THE POSITION AND MOVEMENT OF THE ACTORS ON STAGE

Up stage

THE PART OF THE STAGE THAT IS FURTHEST FROM THE AUDIENCE.



Spike Marks

MARKINGS ON THE STAGE THAT INDICATE WHERE PROPS, FURNITURE, AND SOMETIMES ACTORS, ARE TO BE PLACED.

Running Crew

RUNNING CREW: TECHNICAL CREW WHO MOVE FURNITURE ON AND OFF THE STAGE, BRING IN BACK-DROPS AND OTHER LARGE SET PIECES.



#CROSSCAPTURES
PHOTO FEATURE

THE WORLD

THROUGH A LENS

THE WORLD
THROUGH A LENS,
HOLDING ONTO
TODAY'S MILESTONES.
WEATHERED HANDS
CAPTURING DIGITAL
MEMORIES, BRIDGING
THE GAP BETWEEN
THE EXPERIENCE OF
RIGHT NOW AND THE
STORIES OF
TOMORROW.



REVIEW



IMDb

★★★★★
7.8/10

IMDb

★★★★★
7.8/10

IMDb

★★★★★
8/10

IMDb

★★★★★
8.6/10

IMDb

★★★★★
7.7/10

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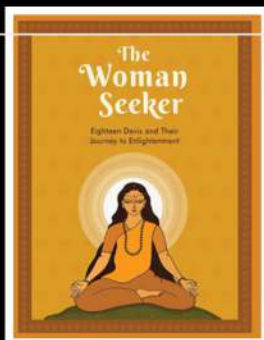
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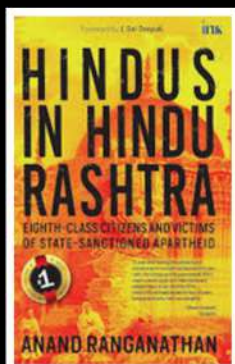


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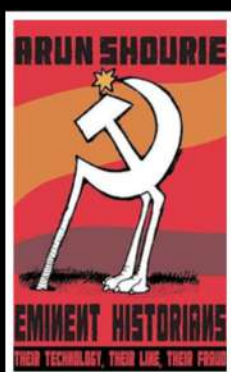


Amazon:

5/5

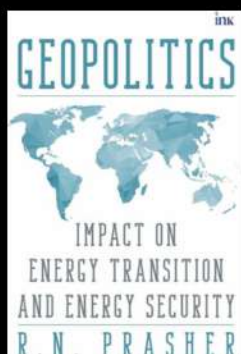


Amazon: 4.8/5

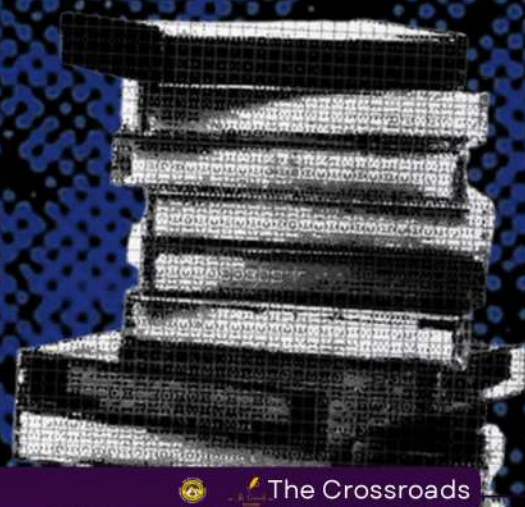
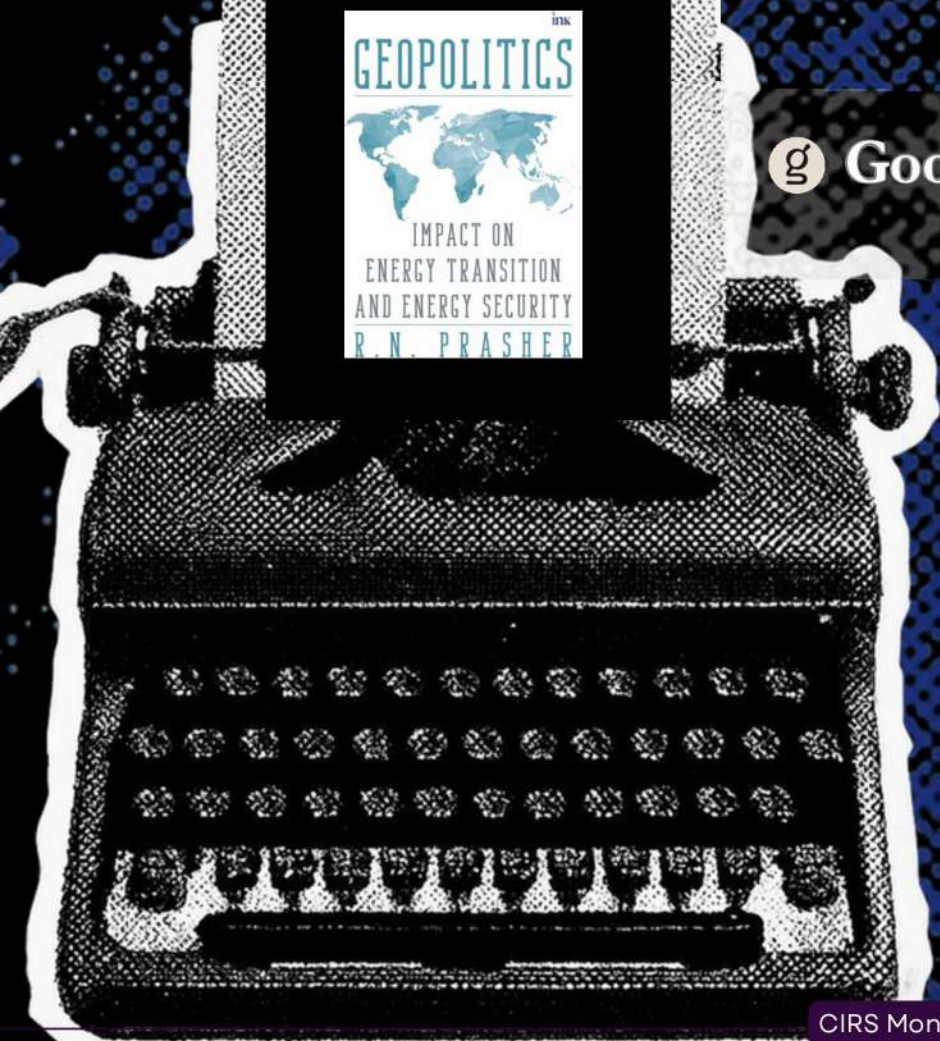


Goodreads:

4.38/5



Goodreads: 3.9/5



WHEN FOMO BECOMES EXPENSIVE

Imagine this: one of your favourite music bands is on a world tour, and they are fortunately coming to India as well. You want to attend it, but you know that you need to start saving up for that new laptop you desperately need. During the ticketing period, you just happened to scroll through your Instagram feed, and all you see is the number of people who have bought the tickets and used reels to express their happiness. You watch one video, and your mind cannot help but want to watch one more, being genuinely happy for all those who were able to procure tickets. This continues for 3 more days, with each day featuring new faces celebrating their booking confirmation. And on the morning of the fifth day, you somehow have the tickets to the concert in your hands!

You have no idea what made you take such a crazy decision, knowing the importance of the new laptop and the irrelevance of the tickets. This is where the 'irrationality' of the human race comes into the picture. What is the reason behind making such irrational decisions? Why do humans regret not buying something that everyone else has? Why does the fear of missing out mess with our minds?

We generally give into the existence of these frequent 'nudges' which indirectly lead us to make decisions that we weren't planning to take. This is where the psychology of economics plays its mind games. In simple words, when you find yourself drawn to buying something you look at everyone else having or figuring that everyone else on social media owns it, it activates a few threads in your mind which are primarily the unholy trinity of Loss Aversion, Social Conformity and the Cascading of Information.

Loss aversion is the bias that the human brain forms to avoid possible losses. Basically, the brain tells us that since the commodity

is only available currently, if not purchased immediately, we will lose the opportunity to buy it and would hurt more than actually losing some money and buying the product! Thus resulting in a sudden and urgent need to buy the product and leading to an irrational decision.

Similarly, the social conformity heuristic in humans intensifies impulsive purchases. Looking at everyone else generates a sense of 'not being accepted' if one does not possess the same object. In an experiment conducted by Solomon Asch, a social psychologist in the 1950s, he was successfully able to prove the fact that even if one believes in something else individually, they tend to give into what everyone else thinks. Behavioral economists say that this is because people want to be accepted by their community and thus tend to make decisions that fit into their society's norms, behaviour, and traditions.

And finally, the last member of this unholy trinity is the Cascading of Information. Everything on the internet has been passed down with various comments and compliments. One product can be twisted into the most useless thing on the planet or exemplified as the one product that everyone needs "to make life easier". This constant availability of online



“bestsellers”, review ranks, and flash sales leads consumers to not rely on their own research and blindly trust the reviews they see on the internet, thus leading them to make misinformed and hasty decisions based on unreliable information.

Now that we know the psychology behind why we buy something we do not intend to, how can we stop ourselves from actually purchasing a product or reduce the craving of owning something just because we have a deeply induced fear of missing out?

In the second chapter of the Bhagavad Gita, Lord Krishna tackles this very problem - of getting lured into external objects because others possess them, getting attached to the idea of having them, and forming a restless craving to acquire them. Krishna ji tells us that the solution to the problem is not in trying to give up buying anything at all or refraining from purchasing.

Through this verse from the second chapter of the Bhagavad Gita he tells us that one should live life free of (Viyukth) Raga - attraction towards the belongings of others and



रागद्वेषवियुक्तैस्तु विषयानिन्द्रियैश्चरन् ।
आत्मवश्यैर्विधेयात्मा प्रसादमधिगच्छति ॥ 2.64 ॥



Dvesa - dwelling in the fear of being left out or as we call it - the fear of loss aversion. He advises training the senses to obey the intellect rather than the emotional or physical self. In layman's terms, He wants us to think twice before we feel like buying something we do not require. To overcome the desires on the physical level and genuinely consider the need to buy it. He tells us how FOMO hijacks our reasoning power and therefore controls our decision-making. By constantly checking ourselves to ensure that we are buying the right things, He promises 'Prasada' - a state of mental clarity and contentment.

The decision has always been in the hands of the individual: to succumb to the constant pulling of the threads or to resist these biases. If you want the latter, then keep in mind that this can only be achieved if you truly know what you are looking for and are not swayed by your desires, because in the end, FOMO is just another distraction that we cannot afford.



Shagun Parmanandka IB-IYR



Captures

@CIRS



Smiles

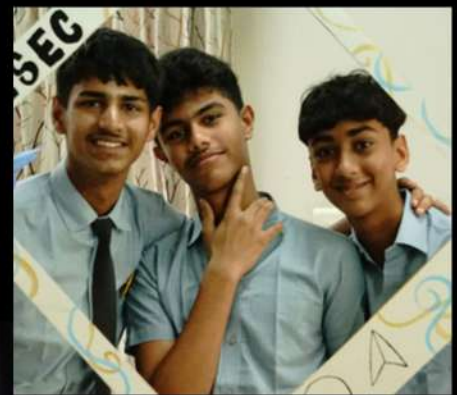




Joy



Curiosity



2026

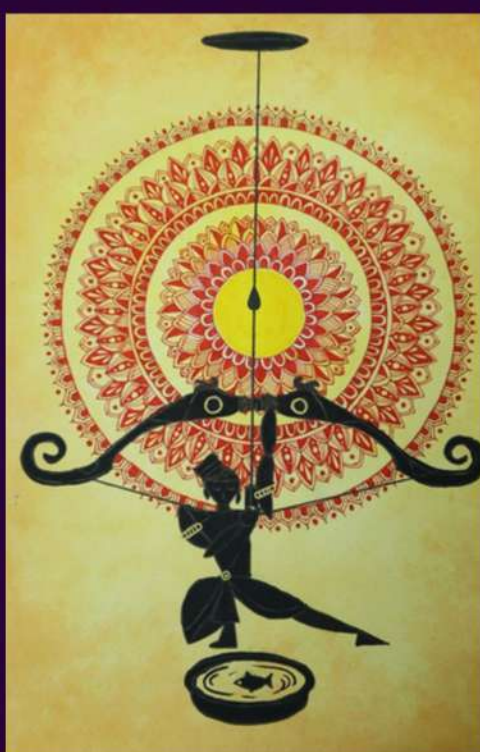




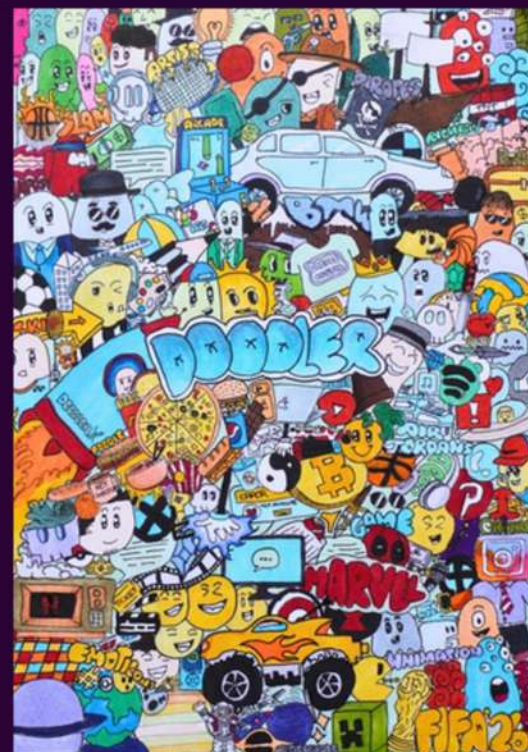
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Deevam S - VII 



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Hitansh A Jain - IB I 



Harshita Bondi a- XI 



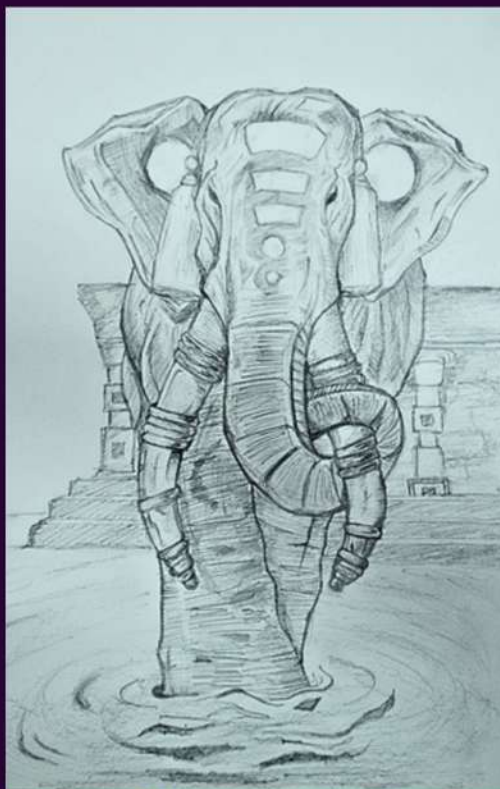
Pirai Soodan - IX 



Neeharika Reddy - IB I 📷



Kabir Kedia - VII 🎨



Muhil - IB I 🎨



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Yuvika A - IX 🎨



Shreshth Kedia - XII 📷



Adhav S - IX 🎨



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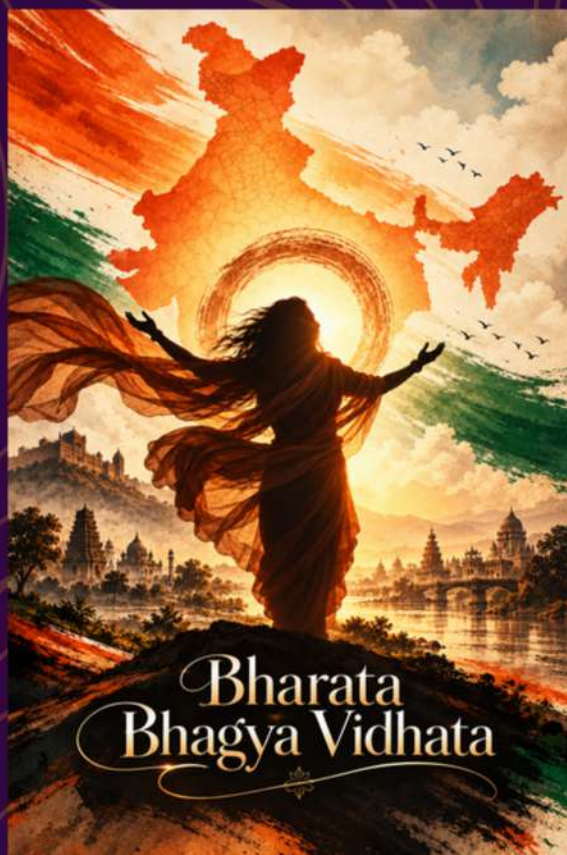
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Bharata Bhagya Vidhata: Dispenser of Destiny

Who was Tagore's Bharata Bhagya Vidhata? This is the same question that plagues all of us each time we sing our National Anthem. Inspired by Rabindranath Tagore's timeless composition- 'Jana Gana Mana', this year's Anand Utsav cultural program aims to answer exactly that very question- Who is the dispenser of Bharat's destiny? Who is the ruler of the minds of the people?

Don your thinking caps and be prepared to solve this mystery alongside Rabindranath Tagore himself in a journey through India's diverse history.

Consider this your invitation to 'Bharata Bhagya Vidhata: Dispenser of Destiny'.

Our gratitude to the CIRS management for giving flight to our initiative.

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